Annex A. Blameless post-mortem template

A template for analyzing an incident without looking for someone to blame. Copy it, fill it in with the team and keep it next to the ticket.

Note for the facilitator: start the meeting by reading the Prime Directive (section 1) out loud. The goal is to understand **how the system allowed the error to happen**, not who pressed the button.

Post-mortem report: [short name of the incident]

Field	Value
Incident date	DD/MM/YYYY
Investigation lead	[name]
Status	Under review / Completed

1 Prime Directive

> "Regardless of what we discover today, we start from the premise that everyone did the best job they could with the information, tools, time and resources available at that moment."

Adapted from the "Prime Directive" of retrospectives (Norm Kerth, 2001).

2 Executive summary

A short description of what happened, what impact it had on users or on the system, and, broadly, how it was resolved.

- **What failed?**
- **Impact:** (e.g., 15% of transactions failed for 2 hours).

3 Timeline of events

An objective timeline. Avoid personal names: use roles or system actions.

- 14:00 – Version X is deployed to production.

- 14:05 – The alerting system detects a spike of 500 errors in the payments module.
- 14:12 – The on-call team receives the notification and starts triage.
- 14:30 – The change to the `DB_TIMEOUT` environment variable is identified as the cause of the blockage.
- 14:45 – Rollback to the previous version. System stable.

4 Root cause analysis (the 5 whys)

A method for getting to the systemic problem. It works as a guide, not as a rule: an incident usually has **several** causes, which are collected in section 6.

1. Why did payments fail? *Because the database didn't respond in time.*
2. Why didn't it respond in time? *Because the timeout parameter was drastically reduced.*
3. Why was it reduced? *Because the configuration was unified with the testing environment.*
4. Why was it unified without validating the impact? *Because the review of environment variables is manual and isn't documented in the pipeline.*
5. Why is it manual? *Because there is no configuration management tool that validates limits per environment.*

5 AI involvement in the change

Fill in if the code involved was generated or assisted by AI. This section doesn't aim to assign blame to the tool or to the person: it aims to understand which part of the process was left without human understanding.

- **Tool and context:** which tool was used and what context (files, requirements, constraints) did it receive?
- **Prompt or instruction:** what exactly was asked? Was information about the business rule missing?
- **What was actually reviewed:** was there a line-by-line read, tests of our own, manual testing? Who approved?
- **Understanding:** can the team today explain what that change does and which cases it doesn't cover?
- **Cases not considered:** which edge cases or exceptional situations weren't taken into account?

6 Contributing factors (the environment)

Which elements of the environment or of the tools made it easier for the error to happen?

- **Lack of visibility:** monitoring didn't show the connection saturation right away.
- **Outdated documentation:** the deployment manual didn't mention the dependencies of that variable.
- **Pressure from deadlines or metrics:** (fill in if applicable).

7 Where we got lucky and what we still don’t know

- **Luck:** what could have gone worse and didn’t? (e.g., the incident happened outside peak hours).
- **Unknowns:** which questions remain open? What can’t we explain yet?

8 Action and mitigation plan

Concrete tasks, **with an owner and a date**, to make the system more robust. **No action can be “the developer should be more careful”.**

Preventive or corrective action	Owner	Priority (High / Medium / Low)	Target date	Ticket
Automate the validation of variables in the CI/CD pipeline	[role or name]	High	DD/MM	PROD-1234
Set up specific alerts for the database connection pool	[role or name]	Medium	DD/MM	PROD-1235
Update the architecture documentation of the payments module	[role or name]	Low	DD/MM	PROD-1236

9 Learning to share

One or two sentences the team can take away, written without personal names and fit to be published.

A post-mortem without closed actions is an empty ritual. Review the status of the table in section 8 at the next retrospective.